

Script and Language

- Script and language is **undeciphered**, script is **pictographic** in nature. Fish symbol is most represented.
- Overlapping of the letters show that it was written from right to left in the first line and then left to right in the second line. The style is called **boustrophedon**. A signboard inscription bearing 10 pictographs has been found from Dholavira in Gujarat.

Decline of Indus Valley Civilisation

It is believed by historians many factors contributed to decline of this ancient civilisation.

Decline of Indus Civilisation : Different Views

Cause of Declines	Thinkers
External Aggression	Wheeler, Piggot, Gordan-childe
Inundation	MR Sahani
Epidemic	KVR Kennedy
Tectonic Disturbances (e.g. Dholavira)	Marshall and Raikes
Sudden Decline	Wheeler
Climatic Change	RL Stein, AN Ghosh
Deforestation, scarcity of resources, ecological imbalances	Walter Fairservis
Flood (e.g., Mohenjodaro)	Marshall, SR Rao, Maickey
The destruction due to change in course of river Ghaggar	GF Holes

Contribution of Indus Valley Civilisation

- The Harappan Civilisation which flourished between 2600 BC and 1900 BC had major contributions. Some of them include standardised weight and measures, planned city construction, public buildings like Great Bath. The Harappans worshipped fire, Mother goddess, tree, phallus which was carried forward by the Aryans.
- The agricultural practise, use of seals for trade, ornaments and dresses were also great contribution of Harappans. Hence, the impact of Harappan civilisation could be seen on socio, economic, political and religious life of the people.

THE VEDIC AGE

The history of Vedic Age is known largely through its religious texts, the vedas, which gave the period its name. The vedas recorded not only the religion of the vedic people, but also details of their lives that give us a look at their Political, Social and Economic pattern.

The Aryans

The word Aryan is derived from Arya, which mean favourably disposed towards new corners and later it implied high birth, but generally, it refers to a language and not race.

- There are many theories about the origin of these people. The most accepted view is that they lived in the great steppe land which stretches from Poland to Central Asia. They were semi-nomadic people. In 2nd millennium BC, they started moving from their original home and migrated Eastwards and Southwards.
- The Boghaz Koi **inscriptions** dated to 1400 BC gives the information about peace treaty between the Hittites and the Mittanis rulers of the Hittani, in which the names of the Vedic Gods Indra, Mitra, Nasatya and Varuna are mentioned. This supports the view, of the Central Asian homeland theory that Central Asia being the homeland, of Aryan. *Vedic age was divided into two parts*

Early Vedic or Rigvedic Age

- The main source of information for the study of early Vedic age people is the Rigveda. The founders of the Vedic culture, were the Aryans, probably immigrant people whose first arrival in India is dated around 2000-1500 BC.
- The Rig Veda gives us information that Aryans first settled at the region called 'Sapta Sindhu or the land of seven rivers' (Presently that region is — East Afghanistan, Punjab and West Uttar Pradesh)-Indus, Jhelum, Ravi, Chenab, Beas, Sutlej and Saraswati.

The Rig Vedic Economy

- Early Aryans were semi-nomadic and later on, they became cultivator. They gave great preference to the cattle, so the ruling class was warriors, who were able to fight for cattle.
- In cattle, 'cow' was preferable. The word 'Gauri' (cow) is mentioned 176 times in Rig Veda. Many more terms related with the word 'Gau' like Gavishti means search for cows, Godhuli for daughter are found. The term Aghanya (not to be killed) has been used for cows.

The Rig Vedic Society

- The Rig vedic society was based on kinship. The early Aryans were essentially tribal and egalitarians. Tribe was called Jana. Society was patriarchal, male child (who fought for the cattle) was preferred.
- Existence of joint family pattern. Eldest male member of the family was known as Kulapa.
- 'Varna' was the term used for colour and it seems that the Aryan language speakers were fair and the indigenous inhabitants were dark in complexion.
- No evidence of caste system is found. Members of same family indulged in different occupation. This is well illustrated in a hymn of 9th mandala. Non-Aryans were called Dasas or Shudras.

- Women possessed respectable status in the society, took part in tribal assemblies, in religious sacrifices along with their husbands. Child marriage was not in existence. The marriageable age was 16 or 17 years for girls. Polygamy and polyandry both existed, but monogamy was in fashion. There was no *Purdah* system.
- Widow remarriage and Niyoga prevailed in society.

The Rig Vedic Polity

- The head was the supreme of the tribe or Jana. He worked on the collective response of the tribal assemblies. Tribal assemblies were Sabha, Samiti, Gana and Vidhata. Vidhata was the oldest one. These assemblies upheld every important activity (like social, military, religious, etc).
- The samitis were comprising the whole clan. The sabha was a selected group of elderly people. Vidhata was engaged in redistributive functions. Chief was called Gopati. Women were allowed in Sabha and Vidhata.
- Vajrapati was the officer of pasture, led by Kulapa (the family head) and Gramini in war. Senani was another important functionary after Purohita. Military functions were performed by tribal units like *rata*, *gana*, *grama*. Tax known as Bali was voluntary.

The Rig Vedic Religion

- The early vedic people were nature worshippers. Neither they had temples nor idols. They prayed by the means of recitation of *Mantra*.
- The motive of worship was to get *Praja* (children), *Pasu* (cattle) and *Dhana* (wealth), till that time they didn't aspire for spiritual upliftment.

Rivers Mentioned in the Rig Veda

<i>Rig Vedic Name</i>	<i>Modern Name</i>
Sindhus	Indus
Vitasta	Jhelum
Askini	Chenab
Parushni	Ravi
Vipasa	Beas
Shatudri	Sutlej
Gomal	Gomati
Krumu	Kurram
Drishadvati	Ghaggar
Suvasthu	Swat
Kubha	Kabul
Naditarna	Saraswati
Sadanira	Gandak

Gods

During Rig vedic period Agni, Indra, Varuna, Soma, Dyaus, Ashwin, Pushan and Surya were the prominent gods. Usha, Aditi, Ratri and Sandhya were the worshipped goddess.

The Later Vedic Age

The expression later Vedic age comprises the far reaching changes and developments that took place in the religion, social, economic and political conditions of the people during the period when the later Sanhitas Sama Veda, Yajur Veda and Atharva Veda and the Brahmanas, Aranyak and Upanishads were composed. The age is also known as Painted Grey Ware (PGW) iron phase.

Geographical Extent

- During the later Vedic period, Aryans moved into Eastward and Southward areas. A study of the literature reveals that moving from Punjab, the Aryans settled in Delhi and upper gangetic doab.
- The story of Agni and Videha Madhava moving Eastward, as narrated in Satapatha Brahmana, gives a proof of the Eastward march.

Social Life

- The four-fold division of society became clear-initially based on occupation, which later became hereditary *Brahmins* (Priests), *Kshatriyas* (Warriors), *Vaishyas* (Agriculturists, cattle-rearers, traders) and *Sudras* (servers of the upper three).
- Women enjoyed freedom and respect, but their status deteriorated compared to earlier time. The institution of *gotra* appeared in this age first time. *Gotra* signified descent from common ancestors.
- Concept of four Ashrams came into being it consisted four stages of life— *Brahmacharya*, *Grihastha*, *Vanaprastha* and *Sanyas*. Chariot racing was main sport and gambling was the main past time.



PURUSHASUKTA THEORY

Purushasukta is a late hymn of 10th Mandal of Rigveda. The hymn says that four persons originated from the body of the Purusha or the primeval creator. The Brahmana (mouth), the Kshatriya (arms), the Vaishya (thighs) and the Shudra (feet).

Political Organisation

- Tiny tribal settlements were replaced by strong kingdoms. A regular army was maintained for the protection of kingdom.
- Powers of the king (Samrat) was increased. Importance of assemblies declined. Women were no longer permitted to attend assemblies. The term 'rashtra' indicating territory first appeared in this period.
- References of priest (*Purohita*), Commander in chief (*Senapati*), Charioteer (*Suta*), Treasurer (*Sangrahita*), Tax collector (*Bhagdugha*), Chief queen (*Mahisi*) and the game companion (*Aksavapa*).

Religion

Rise of Vishnu alongside Rudra new Gods (Vishnu, Rudra, Prajapati etc) came into prominence. Rig Vedic Gods (Indra, Varuna etc) lost prominence. Sacrifices became more elaborate. Increase in the prestige and importance of priestly class. Emergence of new philosophical concepts.

Sacrifices Performed in Later Vedic Period

- **Rajasuya Consecration Ceremony** This conferred supreme power on the king. The Rajasuya sacrifice consists of five major ritual or ceremonies. Asvamedha horse sacrifice which was meant to establish kings supremacy over his neighbours. The Aitareya and Shatapatha Brahmana mention the names of some monarchs, who performed the sacrifice.
- **Ratnahanimasi Ceremony** The king had to approach dignitaries who lived in permanent dwellings. Vajapeya chariot race which was meant to re-establish his supremacy over his own people within the kingdom.

Pottery

The later Vedic people used black and redware, black-strippedware, painted greyware pottery. Redware was most popular with them and has been found almost all over Western Uttar Pradesh. However, the most distinctive pottery of the period is known as Painted Greyware, which comprised bowls and dishes, used either for rituals or for eating by the upper classes.

Economic Life

- The shift towards Gangetic valley with the use of iron and fire made possible the growth of agriculture. Pastoralism was no longer the main subsistence activity of the people, though cattle rearing was also practised.
- Shatapatha Brahmana describes the various stages of agriculture such as ploughing, sowing, reaping and threshing. Both kharif and rabi crops were grown.
- Rice (*Vrihi*) and wheat (*Godhuma*) become the chief crops of the later Vedic Aryans, though they continued to produce barley (*Yava*).

VEDIC LITERATURE

- The word 'Veda' is derived from Sanskrit word vid, meaning to know, signifying knowledge par excellence. The Vedic text are shruti i.e. directly revealed to authors by God.
- Smritis are remembered and collected parts of literature of later period. They are also called samhitas in the sense that they represent oral tradition of the time.
- Four vedas and their Samhitas, the Brahmanas, the Aranyakas and the Upanishads form a class of literature known as **shruti**.

The Rig Veda

It is divided into 10 books or mandalas. Mandala II to VII are considered the oldest and known as family mandalas. Book I, VIII and X seem to be added later.

It dated 1500 BC-1000 BC. It has 1028 hymns written by number of priestly families. The Rig Veda was written when Aryans were still in Punjab. Book II to VII are earliest and are attributed to Gritsamada, Vishvamitra, Vasudeva, Atri, Bhardwaj, Vashishtha, Kanva and Angiras. Rig Veda is recited by **Hotri**. Gayatri mantri is in 3rd mandal of Rig Veda.

The Yajur Veda

It is a ritualistic Veda. Written in prose, it deals with procedure for performance of sacrifices and contain rituals as well as hymns. It is divided into Shukla Yajur Veda (poetry) (including Vajasneyi samhita) and Krishna Yajur Veda (prose and poetry) (Katha, Matriyani and Taittiriya, Vapisthal samhita in which mantra and Brahmanas part are not separated). Yajur Veda is recited by **Adhvaryu**.

The Sama Veda

Word Sama derived from the root word saman means melody/music. It has 1603 verses, but except 99, all the rest of the hymns have been borrowed from the Rig Veda. It contains Dhrupada Raga. The Sama Veda shows that the Aryans loved music and were not merely puritans. Sama Veda is recited by udgatri.

The Atharva Veda

The Atharva Veda is entirely different from the other three Vedas and is the last of the four Vedas. The **Satapatha Brahmana** used the term **trayi**, i.e. the Rig Veda, Yajur Veda and Sama Veda.

Atharva Veda mentions beliefs and practices of non-Aryans. It contains magical *mantra* etc. In it, the sabha and the Samiti are described as sisters and the two daughters of *prajapati*. This Veda is also known as **Brahma Veda**.

Smriti Literature

The Smriti literature contains following

The Brahmanas

These are the prose commentaries on various Vedic hymns. They explain the vedas in an orthodox way. They explain the hidden meanings behind the hymns of Brahmanas. They are expressions of the cause (*hetu*). Shatapatha Brahmana is the largest Brahmana book. It has the story of Madhav.

The Aranyakas

The authors of the Aranyakas were sages dwelling in the forest and explained vedic texts for their pupils in the form of Aranyakas. So, these Aranyakas are known as **forest books**. They form the concluding part of Brahmanas.

Upavedas

These are subsidiary Vedas dealing with secular subjects.

Four important upavedas are as follow

- i. **Ayur Veda** Pertains to medicine.
- ii. **Dhanur Veda** Pertains to art of warfare.
- iii. **Gandharva Veda** Pertains to music.
- iv. **Shilpa Veda** Pertains to art and literature.

The Upanishads

The term Upanishads indicates knowledge acquired by sitting close to the teacher.

- Under it, many metaphysical topics were discussed, such as the origin of universe, the nature of God, the origin and death of mankind etc.
- They do not believe in orthodox rituals and sacrifices. On the contrary, they are the followers of Karma (Action), Atma (Soul) and God (Brahma). They are spiritual and philosophical in nature. Also known as Vedanta or the end of Vedas. They always preaches the *Jnana marga* (knowledge path).
- Upanishads are 108 in number. **Satyamev Jayate** is extracted from Mundako Upanishad. **Brihadaranyaka Upanishad** provides the first reference of the idea of rebirth. Later, this idea appears in full form in the Chandogya upanishad.

Vedangas (Limbs of Vedas)

- These are treatises on Science and Arts. *The six vedangas are as follow*
 - *Shiksha* (phonetics), *Kalpa* (rituals), *Vyakarna* (grammar), *Chanda* (metrics), *Nirukta* (etymology), *Jyotisha* (astronomy). *Yaska's Nirukta* (5th century BC) is the oldest linguistic text.

Epics

Mahabharata It is believed to be written by **Ved Vyas** and is older than 'Ramayana'. Originally Mahabharata consisted of 880 verses then it was raised to 24000 verses. The final compilation brought the number of verses to 100000. Razmnama is translation of Mahabharata in Persian language.

Ramayana It is known as Aadikavya, written by Valmiki in Sanskrit. In it, capital of Kaushal Mahajanapad, Ayodhya (Saket) has been mentioned. Persian translation of Ramayana is written by Badayuni. Tamil translation of Ramayana is written by Kampan. It is also known as Bible of South India. Presently, Ramayana have 24000 shlokas. *Ramcharitmanas* was written by Tulsidas in Awadhi language.

Puranas The word 'Purana' means old. Writer of Puranas is Lomharsh's son Ugrvarsh. It was written in AD 4th century in Gupta age. Number of Puranas are 18. Oldest Purana is Matsya Purana. It tells about Satvahana dynasty. In Purana, 10 avtar of Vishnu has been mentioned. Vayu Puran gives details about Gupta dynasty.

SHAD DARSHAN

(Six Systems of Philosophy)

- **Nyaya** (Analysis) *Gautam*
- **Vaisesika** (Atomic characteristic) *Kanada*
- **Sankhya** (Enumeration) *Kapil*
- **Yoga** (Application) *Patanjali*
- **Purva Mimansa** (Enquiry) *Jaimini*
- **Uttar Mimansa** (Vedanta) *Vyasa*

Mahajanapadas

During the age of Buddha, we find 16 large states called Mahajanapadas mentioned in Buddhist text Angkuttar Nikaya. These Mahajanapadas were either monarchical or republican in character.

The sixteen Mahajanapadas are as follow

Mahajanapada	Capital	Mahajanapada	Capital
Kashi	Varanasi	Kuru	Hastinapur, Indraprastha and Isukara
Kosala	Shravasti	Panchala	Ahichhatra and Kampilya
Anga	Champa	Matsya	Viratnagar
Magadh	Girivraj or Rajgriha	Surasena	Mathura
Vajji	Vaishali	Ashmaka	Pratisthana
Malla	Kushinagar and Pavapuri	Avanti	Mahismati
Chedi	Shuklamati	Gandhara	Taxila
Vatsa	Kausambi	Kamboja	Rajpur ot Hataka

RISE OF JAINISM AND BUDDHISM

During 5th-6th centuries BC two new religion emerged in the form of Jainism and Buddhism.

Jainism

- The founder of Jainism was *Mahavira*. He was born in 540 BC as Vardhamana (childhood name) at *Kundagrama* near Vaishali. His father Siddhartha was the head of a famous Kshatriya clan, and his mother, named Trishala, was the sister of Chetaka, the king of Vaishali. He was also related to Bimbisara, the ruler of Magadha, who had married Chellana, the daughter of Chetaka.
- During the early stages Mahavira joined a group of ascetics called Nirgranthas. Parsa was the founder of this sect. Mahavira attained *Kaivalya* (perfect knowledge) under sal tree, near village Jimbhikagrama, on the bank of the river Rijupalika and died at the age of 72 at Pavapuri near modern Rajgir in 468 BC.

- After the death of Mahavira, during the reign of king Chandragupta Maurya (the founder Mauryan empire), a severe famine led to the migration of some Jains under Bhadrabahu to the Deccan. Sthula bhadra remained in North and allowed wearing white garments. Bhadrabahu maintained nudity leading to division as *Digambaras* (sky clad or naked) and *Svetambaras* (white clad).
- There are 24 Tirthankaras in the history of Jainism. Mahavir Swami was the last and the 24th Tirthankara of Jainism.

Preachings of Mahavira

- Rejected the authority of the Vedas and the Vedic rituals. Did not believe in the existence of God.
- Attainment of salvation (Moksha) by believing penance and dying of starvation. Laid great emphasis on equality or universal brotherhood.
- *In Jainism, there are three Ratnas and they are called the Way of Nirvana.*
 - i. Right faith—*Samyak Vishwas*
 - ii. Right knowledge—*Samyak Gyan*
 - iii. Right conduct—*Samyak Karma*
- *There are five main teachings of Jainism*
 - i. Non-injury (*Ahimsa*)
 - ii. Non-lying (*Satya*)
 - iii. Non-possession (*Aparigraha*)
 - iv. Non-stealing (*Asteya*)
 - v. Observe continence (*Brahmacharya*)
- The first four principles were given by Parsavanath and fifth one i.e. Brahmacharya was added by Mahavira.

Tirthankaras and their Symbols

Name	Symbol	Name	Symbol
Rishabha	Bull	Vimalnath	Boar
Ajithnath	Elephant	Ananthnath	Falcon
Sambharanath	Horse	Dharmnath	Vajra
Abhinandan Swami	Monkey	Shantinath	Deer
Sumathinath	Curlew	Kunthunath	He-Goat
Padamprabhu	Red Lotus	Arnath	Fish
Suparshvanatha	Swastik	Mallinath	Jar (Kalash)
Chandraji Prabhu	Moon	Muniswasth	Tortoise
Suvidhinath	Crocodile	Naminath	Blue Lotus
Shitalnath	Kalpa-Vriksha	Neminath	Conch Shell
Shreyansnath	Rhinoceros	Parsavanath	Serpent (Snake)
Vasupujya	Buffalo	Mahavira	Lion

Jain Councils

- First council was held at Pataliputra (Bihar) by Sthulbhadra, in the beginning of the 3rd century BC and resulted in the compilation of 12 Angas to replace 14 Purvas.

- Second council was held at Vallabhi (Gujarat) in the AD 512 under the leadership of Devardhi and resulted in final compilation of 12 Angas and 12 Upangas.

Jain Literature

The sacred books of the Jains are known as **Siddhartha** or Agama, *it include*

- | | |
|--------------------|------------------------|
| i. Twelve Angas | ii. Twelve Upangas |
| iii. Ten Prikarnas | iv. Six Chhedasutras |
| v. Four Mulasutras | vi. Two Sutra Granthas |

They are written in Prakrit language. Among the Jain writers, the most important were Bhadrabahu (*Kalpa-Sutra*), Siddhasena, Divakara, Manibhadra, Siddha, Hemachandra (Parisistha Parvan), Nayachandra and Mallinath. The Jains wrote narrative literature, kavyas, novels, dramas and hymns.

Buddhism

Founded by Gautam Buddha (Sakyamuni or Tathagat) known originally as Siddhartha (childhood name).

Buddha's Life

- He was born in 563 BC (widely accepted) in a sal grove of Lumbini garden in Kapilavastu. His mother was Mahamaya (a Kosalan princess) and his father was Sudhodhana (of Sakya tribe).
- Buddha's name was Siddhartha and gotra was Gautama. His mother died after 7 days of his birth and he was brought up by his Step-mother *Mahaprajapati* Gautami. Devadutta was his cousin. Buddha's wife was Yashodhara and she gave birth to their son Rahul. Buddha's charioteer was Channa and favourite horse was Kanthak.
- He was moved by the misery, which people suffered in the world and looked for its solution. He left home at the age of 29. This incident became famous as Mahabhinishkramana— 'great going forth'.
- He first became a disciple of Alara Kalam. Kalam was the specialist of Samakhya philosophy. After sometime, he left Alara and joined Rudraka. From there, he went to Uruvela and practised great penance. His conception of religion was purely ethical.
- Buddha got enlightenment under the pipal tree known as Bodhi tree at Gaya in Bihar. He gave his first sermon at Sarnath (ancient name was Rishipattan) first sermon became famous by the name of *Dharma Chakrapravartan* (or the turning of wheel of law).
- He spent his last days near Vaishali. At Pava, a man named Chunda fed him pork, after eating it Buddha died of dysentery at the age of 80 in 483 BC in Kushinagar, the capital of Mallas. His death is known *Mahaparinirvana* i.e. final blowing out. His favourite disciple was Ananda.